

HASHKAMA WEEKLY



פרשת כי תשא

י' אדר תשפ"ו

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חכמה ב-א' תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

In Parshas Ki Sisa, we encounter the tragic moment of the Chet HaEgel (Sin of the Golden Calf). When Moshe Rabbeinu descends Har Sinai and witnesses the dancing around the idol, he throws down the Luchos (Tablets) and shatters them (Shemos 32:19). The Meshech Chochmah (Rav Meir Simcha of Dvinsk, in his commentary on this verse) explains a profound concept regarding this drastic action. Moshe realized that Bnei Yisroel (the Children of Israel) were inherently treating the Luchos—and perhaps even Moshe himself—as independent holy objects, making the same fundamental mistake they made with the Egel. To completely uproot this dangerous misconception, Moshe shattered the holiest physical objects on earth, fiercely demonstrating that nothing possesses inherent sanctity except our direct, unmediated relationship with Hakadosh Baruch Hu (The Holy One, Blessed be He). This necessary shattering directly sets the stage for a seemingly less glamorous, but ultimately more enduring, reality: the Luchos Sheniyyos (Second Tablets). Later in the Parsha (Shemos 34:1), Hashem commands Moshe, "Psal lecha"—carve for yourself two stone tablets. Unlike the first Luchos, which were entirely ma'aseh Elokim (the work of God), the second set required intense human sweat and toil. Rav Yitzchok Hutner (Pachad Yitzchok, Maamarei Yom HaKippurim) illuminates this connection beautifully. The first Luchos represented a state of absolute perfection, a pristine gift from Above that simply could not survive contact with human failing. The Luchos Sheniyyos, however, represent the resilient power of teshuva (repentance) and human effort. Because they were born out of our struggle, our terrible failure, and our active rebuilding, they remained whole forever. The fragile perfection of the first was lost, but the hard-earned, human-carved connection of the second became eternal.

Practical Takeaway: The powerful connection between these two events provides our essential avodah (spiritual work) for the week. We often begin new endeavors—a new zman (semester) in learning, a new chavrusashaft (study partnership), or a fiery resolution to attend shacharis (morning prayers) earlier—with the pristine perfection of the first Luchos. Inevitably, we stumble, and those initial perfect plans shatter. Do not despair! That shattering is exactly what clears the way for "psal lecha." The Torah that you carve out through your own sheer stubbornness, and the tefillah (prayer) you fight for when you are utterly exhausted, creates your Luchos Sheniyyos. Pick up your chisel, embrace the daily struggle, and realize that the spiritual edifice you rebuild after a failure is exactly the one that will last forever.

News & Simchos!

Attention Men

New Kiddush Room

Please join us in the newly inaugurated Kiddush Room to gently test its ventilation. Partake in our customary culinary heavyweights—scalding cholent and dense kugel—while politely enduring what we optimistically term a "short" shiur. Your dignified presence at this weekly cholesterol symposium is cordially requested.

Exciting Opportunity!

If you'd like to light up our lives with a sponsorship or add some flavor with a kiddush sponsorship, please

contact Tzvi Zev Rubin:

845-252-1260



Drasha Duty!

To give the Short Shiur after davening, please contact Rabbi Genack:

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Sponsorship

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

1:30 pm	מנחה
5:35 pm	הדלקה
--:-- pm	מנחה - קבלת שבת
5:53 pm	שקיעה
4:59/5:08 am	עלות השחר (16.1/72)
6:20:50 am	נץ החמה
7:15 am	שחרית
Hot kiddush & Shiur after davening	
8:38/9:14 am	סי"ז קריאת שמע
9:47/10:11 am	סי"ז תפילה
12:07:14 pm	חצות היום
12:37:14 pm	מנחה גדולה (30)
3:29:38 pm	מנחה קטנה (גר"א)
4:41:50 pm	פלג המנחה (גר"א)
--:-- pm	מנחה
5:54 pm	שקיעה
6:35/6:44 pm	צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50)
6:46 pm	מעריב (52)
6:54/7:06 pm	צה"כ (60/72)



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

TBA pm	מנחה
6:43 pm	הדלקה
7:01 pm	שקיעה
7:15 am	שחרית
7:02 pm	שקיעה
7:54 pm	מעריב (52)

This Week's Riddle

Riddle: Aside from this parsha, where else in the Torah is a partial list of the 13 attributes of Hashem mentioned?

Answer: In Parshas Shelach, Moshe entreats Hashem through the 13 attributes to forgive the nation for believing the evil report of the spies (Bamidbar 14:18).



Donations & Payments

Zelle: Send to 845-252-1260

Check: Write Out to Bais Midrash 715

Cash: Hand to Tzvi Zev or Adam Edelman

Credit Card: Ask Tzvi Zev Rubin for a link

Gift Card/Bitcoin: Do we look like Indian Scammers to you?

משל ונמשל ב-א תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Mashal: Imagine a determined balabos (layman) who decides he will sponsor and prepare the most magnificent chulent (Sabbath stew) for the shul kiddush (reception), entirely by himself. He figures, why rely on the building committee or the sisterhood? He purchases the finest cuts of meat, the most expensive potatoes, and slow-cooks the concoction for an entire day. However, in his absolute confidence, he completely forgets to include the beans and barley. Shabbos morning arrives, and he proudly serves his creation. The mispallelim (congregants) stare at their bowls in polite confusion. Finally, the gabbai (sexton) sighs and says, "Reb Yisroel, this isn't a chulent; this is simply a very exhausted pot roast." He tried to carry the entire culinary burden alone, but without the humble, seemingly insignificant beans to bind the ingredients and absorb the flavor, the dish completely lacks its essential character. It is an incomplete masterpiece, much like a drasha (sermon) that lacks a polite cough from the front row to signal it is finally time to conclude.

Nimshal: In Parshas Ki Sisa, Hakadosh Baruch Hu (The Holy One, Blessed be He) commands Klal Yisroel (the Jewish people) regarding the collection of the Machatzis HaShekel (the half-shekel coin), found in Shemos 30:13. The pasuk (verse) strictly dictates, "He'ashir lo yarbeh, v'hadal lo yam'it" (The rich shall not give more, and the poor shall not give less). Why must it specifically be a half-coin? The Alshich HaKadosh (Rav Moshe Alshich, on Shemos 30:13) famously explains that an individual Jew is spiritually only considered a half. We are fundamentally incomplete when standing in isolation. A wealthy individual cannot simply write a large check for the whole shekel to buy out his obligation and avoid everyone else. Just as you cannot bake a proper potato kugel (casserole) without combining both the potatoes and the oil, a person who thinks he can achieve shleimus (spiritual perfection) independently is entirely missing the reality of our national character. We only become a complete, functioning entity when we attach our "half" to the "half" of our fellow Jew. Without the rest of the kehilla (congregation), even the most accomplished talmid chochom (Torah scholar) is spiritually akin to that lonely, exhausted pot roast.

Practical Takeaway: This week, as you navigate the complexities of your chavrusashaft (study partnership) or participate in the inevitable, passionate negotiations over the shul thermostat settings, remember the profound lesson of the Machatzis HaShekel. Look closely at the person sitting next to you during davening (prayer). You might privately think his singing is painfully off-key, or that he takes an extraordinarily long time for Shemoneh Esrei (the silent prayer), but the Torah guarantees that you inherently need his half to complete yours. Make a conscious, deliberate effort to reach out to someone outside your immediate social circle. Offer a warm "Gut Shabbos" (Good Sabbath) to someone you usually overlook, or share a brief vort (Torah thought) with a newcomer. We are all just halves of the same cosmic coin, and it is entirely up to us to ensure our community's spiritual bank account does not bounce.

GOOD SHABBUS!